



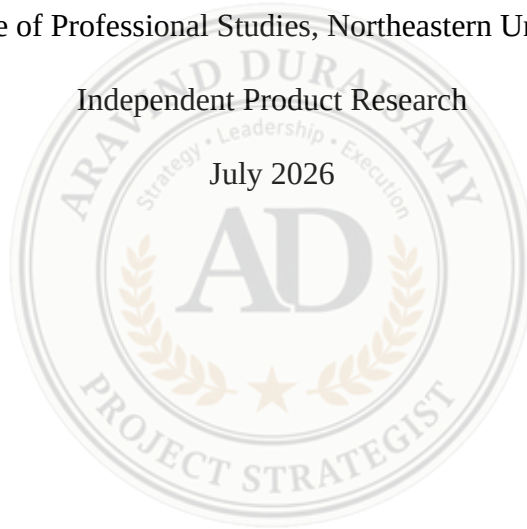
**From Idea to Validated Concept: A Human–AI Collaborative Case Study in Global Project
Management Product Development**

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Abstract

This case study documents a structured, human–AI collaborative process for generating and validating a project management (PM) product concept. Rather than presenting a single idea as a finished pitch, this paper traces three concepts through direct competitive research, showing how two were rejected on evidence and a third was retained as a genuine market gap. The retained concept, a Global Project Readiness Assistant, addresses project-level (not company-level) readiness for cross-border teams, covering holiday calendar conflicts, cultural decision-making norms, and data residency considerations. The paper further documents a deliberate scoping decision, to generate recommendations and route them through existing calendar infrastructure rather than building a competing scheduling engine, and shows how a real market event occurring during this research (Salesforce's 2026 acquisition and shutdown of the calendar-AI startup Clockwise) corroborated that decision. The paper concludes that the primary value of this exercise was not the concept itself but the demonstrated capacity for evidence-based idea validation, a core project management competency.

Keywords: project management, product validation, AI collaboration, global teams, market research, competitive analysis

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Introduction

Portfolio case studies in project management frequently present a single product concept as a polished pitch, with market validation implied rather than demonstrated. This paper takes a different approach. It documents the actual sequence of an idea-generation process conducted collaboratively between the author and an AI assistant (Claude, developed by Anthropic), including the ideas that were proposed and subsequently rejected, the evidence that led to each rejection, and the reasoning that shaped the concept ultimately retained. The intent is to demonstrate a specific project management competency that is difficult to show through a finished artifact alone: the discipline of testing an idea against real market evidence before committing resources to it, and revising or abandoning that idea when the evidence does not support it.

Method

The process began with an open brainstorming request, deliberately unconstrained by the author's own professional background, to avoid anchoring on familiar domains. Three concepts were generated across two sessions. Each concept was then subjected to direct competitive research using web search rather than assumption, following the principle that a market gap claim is only as credible as the evidence used to test it. Two concepts were rejected after this research revealed each occupied a market already served by mature, well-funded competitors. The third concept was retained after research found no dedicated product addressing its specific problem framing, and was developed further through two interactive prototypes and a deliberate discussion of automation scope.

Concept One: AI-Generated Stakeholder Status Reports (Rejected)

The first concept proposed an AI tool that would translate raw technical inputs, such as ticket logs or engineering discussion threads, into stakeholder-appropriate status updates. Initial research identified a free, template-based generator already offered by Taskade for this exact use case, indicating basic demand had already been addressed by an existing product. A refined version of the concept, framed narrowly around translating technical severity into stakeholder-safe language during live incidents, was tested against the incident management software market specifically. This research found the capability already deeply embedded as a standard feature across major incident management platforms, including Rootly, PagerDuty, and incident.io, each of which markets AI-drafted stakeholder communications, automated status page updates, and AI-generated incident summaries as core, bundled functionality (PagerDuty, 2025; Rootly, 2026a, 2026b). The concept was rejected on the basis that it would compete directly with mature, enterprise-adopted functionality rather than fill an unaddressed need.

Concept Two: Currency and FX Risk Tracking for Project Budgets (Rejected)

The second concept proposed a tool to track foreign exchange (FX) exposure tied to specific project milestones and budgets, reasoning that global projects carry currency risk that generic budgeting tools do not surface. Research found FX risk management to be an established, mature software category serving exactly this need at the organizational finance level, with vendors including Kantox, Kyriba, and iBanFirst offering real-time exposure tracking, automated hedging recommendations, and forward-contract management, some marketed specifically toward small and mid-sized businesses (iBanFirst, 2026; Kantox, n.d.; Kyriba, n.d.). Beyond market saturation, this concept was rejected for a second reason: FX hedging carries genuine financial and regulatory complexity that would require domain expertise beyond what a

portfolio-stage prototype could credibly represent, making it a poor candidate for demonstration even if a market gap had existed.

Concept Three: Global Project Readiness Assistant (Retained)

The third concept emerged from a discussion of what global project coordination requires beyond communication tooling: designed time zone handoffs, awareness of local holiday calendars, region-specific decision-making norms, data residency obligations, and political or infrastructure risk. Research distinguished this framing from two adjacent, already-served markets. Company-level market entry readiness, covering hiring, payroll, and legal entity setup, is served by large employer-of-record platforms. Live incident-communication tooling, discussed in Concept One, is served by the incident management platforms already cited. No dedicated product was found addressing project-level readiness: a repeatable check performed by a project manager launching a specific, time-bound initiative with a specific cross-border team composition, rather than a one-time organizational expansion decision. This gap was judged genuine rather than assumed, on the basis that available search results describing this need consisted of general advisory or consulting content rather than software products.

Two interactive prototypes were developed to make the concept concrete. The first generates a readiness brief for a selected set of countries, surfacing holiday conflicts, decision-culture notes, suggested handoff windows, and data residency flags. The second demonstrates an approval-based workflow in which the assistant proposes calendar events with attached reasoning, and a project manager must explicitly approve or skip each one before anything is created on a real calendar.

Scoping the Automation Boundary

A central design decision in this concept was where automation should stop. The reasoning layer, holiday awareness, cultural context, and regulatory flags, was identified as the differentiated, underserved component. The scheduling layer, finding an optimal meeting time and creating a calendar event, was identified as commodity functionality already well served by dedicated calendar-optimization products. The concept was therefore scoped to generate a recommendation and route it into existing calendar infrastructure via integration, rather than building a competing scheduling engine. This decision was made explicitly to avoid duplicating infrastructure that incumbents were better positioned to provide, and to concentrate effort on the judgment layer that no existing tool addressed.

Real-Time Market Validation

During the course of this research, an unplanned market event provided direct evidence for the scoping decision described above. On March 19, 2026, Salesforce announced it had acquired the engineering team behind Clockwise, an AI calendar-optimization startup that had raised \$76 million in funding and served roughly 40,000 organizations, including Uber, Atlassian, and Etsy (AI for Automation, 2026; Dealroom.co, 2026). The standalone Clockwise product was shut down eight days later, on March 27, 2026, with calendar data deleted and approximately one week's notice given to users (byteiota, 2026; usecarly.com, 2026). Clockwise's official recommendation to displaced users was to migrate to Reclaim, a competing calendar-AI product that had itself been acquired by Dropbox in August 2024 (Focus AI Guide, 2026; Vantage Point, 2026). Industry commentary on the shutdown converged on a consistent interpretation: that calendar-optimization AI functions as a feature large platforms are inclined to absorb rather than a business capable of sustaining independent, long-term operation (byteiota, 2026; Focus AI Guide, 2026). This event, occurring independently of and prior to any deliberate search for it,

corroborated the scoping decision to treat calendar scheduling as infrastructure to integrate with rather than a layer to build and defend.

Discussion

This process illustrates a specific and transferable project management skill: evaluating a concept against real evidence and being willing to abandon it when that evidence is unfavorable, rather than defending an idea because effort has already been invested in it. Two of three concepts were rejected using the same evidentiary standard applied to the one that was retained, which distinguishes this exercise from idea generation exercises that present only a winning concept. The broader project management context supports the practical relevance of the retained concept. Industry survey data indicate that a substantial share of organizations lack real-time visibility into project status, that a similarly large share of project managers do not follow a defined methodology, and that overallocated team members make measurably more errors, all of which point to a persistent gap between the volume of available project management tooling and the actual visibility and structure many teams experience day to day (Breeze.pm, 2026; TheBusinessDive, 2026).

Limitations

Several limitations apply. First, the Global Project Readiness Assistant remains a validated concept and interactive prototype rather than a deployed product; its data sources for holiday, cultural, and legal information would require ongoing maintenance by qualified researchers to be trustworthy in production use, a nontrivial and recurring operational cost. Second, the market for this specific need, project-level rather than company-level readiness, is likely small as a standalone business opportunity; it is plausible that in the medium term such a capability would appear as a feature within an existing project management platform rather than sustain an

independent company, a pattern consistent with what this same research observed in the calendar-AI category. Third, competitive landscape research, while conducted directly rather than assumed, was necessarily time-bound and cannot rule out the emergence of new direct competitors after the date of this study. Finally, the human-in-the-loop approval design was a deliberate choice intended to preserve trust and avoid unwanted autonomous action on a user's calendar; this design has not been tested with actual users and its effect on adoption and trust remains a hypothesis rather than a demonstrated outcome.

Conclusion

The primary contribution of this case study is not the Global Project Readiness Assistant concept itself, but the documented process that produced it: a willingness to generate multiple ideas, test each one against direct evidence, discard those that do not withstand scrutiny, and scope the surviving concept's automation boundary deliberately rather than by default. That scoping decision was subsequently corroborated by an independent, real-world market event during the course of this research. For a project management practitioner, the capacity to make and defend this kind of evidence-based go/no-go judgment is arguably more transferable to professional practice than any single product idea, since it is a skill applicable across problem domains rather than tied to one.

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